

son in his stroller through the stores at the mall. Mort never saw evidence of her purchases since she was careful to cut off the price tags before he got home. He was so wrapped up in his work that he hadn't noticed.

Linda had been able to keep this spending a secret for so long because she had been making only the minimum payments on the credit cards. The allowance Mort gave her had been enough to make these small payments. But now Linda had acquired so much debt that she couldn't even make the minimum payments and didn't want to alert her husband by asking for more spending money.

Mort decided to take over her debt payments, but did not want to touch their retirement accounts to pay down the debt. He lectured his clients to never touch their retirement accounts and he wasn't about to become a hypocrite. So he chose to continue working even harder and use the extra income to wipe out her liabilities. Three years later, he had finally paid off every penny.

Imagine his horror when he again discovered that Linda had accumulated an additional \$40,000 in credit card debt! She simply acquired new credit cards and followed the same pattern as before. Worried that the pattern would just repeat itself, Mort went with his wife to a therapist who diagnosed Linda with an overspending addiction. Credit cards were her drug of choice. She used them to alter her mood of loneliness over never being able to spend time with her husband. Once the core reason was discovered, a solution was easy. Mort needed to cut down his hours at work and spend more time with his wife.

Unfortunately, this was not possible if he was to again pay down her debt. The therapist pointed out that his workaholic lifestyle had contributed to the situation in the first place so to continue this pattern would assure the same results. The only solution that remained was to withdraw money from their

